

Communicate Like a CEO

Speak with the clarity, calm and authority of the top 1%.

By the last page you will structure your thoughts under pressure, hold a room, and say hard things without losing respect - whether you are pitching an investor or answering a question in class.

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A note before you begin

Most people believe great communicators are born that way. They are not. The calm executive who answers a tough question in one clean sentence spent years building that skill on purpose. You can build it faster, because you now have a map.

This book is short on theory and long on practice. Every chapter ends with something to do out loud, on camera, or in front of a person. Reading it will teach you nothing. Doing the drills will change how people treat you.

A warning: you will feel awkward the first few times. That awkwardness is the sound of a skill being installed. Push through it and, within weeks, people start describing you with a word you may never have heard about yourself before - 'impressive'.

Contents

- 01 Executive presence starts in your head
 - 02 Say less, mean more
 - 03 Body language and the power of the pause
 - 04 Structure any talk in three moves
 - 05 Persuade without pressure
 - 06 Handle hard conversations and feedback
 - 07 Own the camera and the online room
 - 08 Your CEO-level talk
-

Executive presence starts in your head

Presence is not volume or expensive clothes. It is the visible signal that you are in control of yourself. Before you fix your words, you fix the story you tell yourself in the ten seconds before you speak. Nervous people rehearse the disaster: 'What if I forget, what if they laugh.' Leaders rehearse the outcome: 'I know this. I am here to help them understand it.'

Your body follows your mind, but the reverse is also true. Stand with both feet planted, shoulders down, breathe out slowly before your first word. That single slow exhale drops your voice half a tone and tells your nervous system there is no lion in the room. Do it every time until it is automatic.

IN PRACTICE

Before a big pitch, a founder I mentored used to shake. We changed one thing: three slow breaths and the sentence 'I am the most prepared person in this room.' Same slides, same voice - but investors started leaning in. Nothing changed except what she believed as she walked in.

TRY THIS

Record a 60-second phone video introducing yourself and what you do. Watch it once. Note one thing your body does when nervous (touching your face, looking down, rushing). Record it again, fixing only that one thing.

Key takeaways

- Presence is self-control made visible.
- One slow exhale before you speak lowers your voice and your fear.
- Rehearse the outcome, not the disaster.

Say less, mean more

The fastest way to sound senior is to cut words. Juniors explain everything; leaders lead with the conclusion, then support it. This is called answering first. If your boss asks 'Will we finish by Friday?' do not narrate the whole week. Say: 'Yes - two tasks remain and both are on track.' Headline first, detail on request.

Practise the one-breath rule: your main point should fit in a single breath. If you run out of air before your point lands, it is too long. Write your key message as one sentence before any important conversation. If you cannot, you are not ready to speak yet - you are still thinking out loud.

IN PRACTICE

Two people ask for a raise. The first talks for four minutes about effort and loyalty. The second says: 'I have taken on the reports work that used to need two people. I would like my pay to reflect that.' One breath, one clear ask. Guess who gets taken seriously.

TRY THIS

Take something you explained recently in a long message. Rewrite it as one sentence that leads with the conclusion. Send that version next time.

Key takeaways

- Answer first, explain second.
- If your point does not fit one breath, it is not ready.
- Clarity reads as confidence.

Body language and the power of the pause

People decide how to feel about you before they process your words. Eye contact says 'I am not afraid of you.' An open chest and steady hands say 'I belong here.' You do not need to perform power poses; you need to stop the small habits that leak fear - fidgeting, filler words, and the nervous laugh at the end of your own sentences.

Your most powerful tool is silence. When you finish a point, stop. Do not fill the gap with 'so, yeah, that is basically it.' A confident pause forces attention and signals that you meant what you said. Amateurs fear silence; professionals use it as punctuation.

IN PRACTICE

In interviews, the strongest candidates answer, then go quiet. The weak ones keep talking to fill the pause and undo their good answer. The pause is not empty - it is you holding the frame.

TRY THIS

In your next three conversations, when you finish a sentence, count 'one-two' silently before adding anything. Notice how people lean in to fill the space instead of you.

Key takeaways

- First impressions are physical, not verbal.
- Kill filler words - they leak fear.
- Silence after a point is strength, not a mistake.

Structure any talk in three moves

Whether you have thirty seconds or thirty minutes, a strong message has the same skeleton: the point, the proof, the ask. Point - what you want them to know. Proof - one story, number, or example that makes it real. Ask - what you want them to do next. Most people give proof with no point and no ask, so nothing happens.

This structure works for a WhatsApp voice note, a class presentation, or a funding pitch. It removes rambling because you always know which of the three moves you are in. When you feel lost mid-sentence, ask yourself: point, proof, or ask? - and jump to the next one.

IN PRACTICE

Pitch in three moves: 'We help boda riders in Jinja earn more (point). In our pilot, ten riders raised their weekly income by a third (proof). I am asking for equipment to reach a hundred more (ask).' Twelve seconds. Fundable.

TRY THIS

Pick a topic you care about. Write three lines only: Point, Proof, Ask. Deliver it out loud in under 30 seconds. Trim until it flows.

Key takeaways

- Every message = Point, Proof, Ask.
- One piece of proof beats five weak ones.
- No ask means no result.

Persuade without pressure

Persuasion is not tricking people; it is helping them see why your idea serves what they already want. Start from their world, not yours. Before you propose anything, name their goal or fear out loud: 'You want this delivered without surprises, right?' When people feel understood, their resistance drops and they can actually hear you.

Then bridge from their goal to your idea using the word 'so': 'You want it done right the first time, so I suggest we test with five users before we launch.' Facts inform, but stories move. Wrap your key point in a 20-second real example and it will be remembered long after the meeting ends.

IN PRACTICE

A teacher wanted tablets for her class. She did not lead with the cost. She said: 'You care about pass rates. Here is a girl who could not read last term; with practice on one shared tablet, she now can.' The story sold the tablets.

TRY THIS

Think of something you want someone to agree to. Write the first sentence starting with THEIR goal, not yours. Practise saying it before you make the request.

Key takeaways

- Start from their goal, not your ask.
- Use 'so' to bridge their want to your idea.
- A short true story beats a long argument.

Handle hard conversations and feedback

Leaders are trusted because they can say uncomfortable things cleanly. The formula is simple: be soft on the person, hard on the problem. Describe the behaviour, not the character. 'The report was late twice this week' is workable. 'You are lazy' starts a war. Facts first, feelings owned by you, then a clear request.

When you receive criticism, do not defend instantly. Breathe, say 'thank you, let me think about that,' and separate the useful 10% from the delivery. The ability to take feedback without collapsing or attacking is one of the rarest and most valuable executive skills there is.

IN PRACTICE

Instead of 'you never listen', try: 'When I was interrupted in the meeting, I felt my point was lost. Next time, can I finish before we respond?' Same message - but one keeps the relationship and gets the result.

TRY THIS

Write one difficult thing you need to say to someone. Rewrite it in three parts: the fact, how it affected you, and one clear request. Say it within the week.

Key takeaways

- Soft on the person, hard on the problem.
- Describe behaviour, never label character.
- 'Thank you, let me think' buys you dignity under criticism.

Own the camera and the online room

Most opportunities now begin on a screen - a video call, a voice note, a recorded pitch. The rules shift slightly online. Look at the camera lens, not the faces, so you appear to make eye contact. Sit with light in front of you, not behind. Get close enough that your face fills a good part of the frame; distance reads as disengagement.

On calls, speak a touch slower and pause a beat longer, because there is lag and there are distractions. Start with your point immediately - online attention is short. And when you are not speaking, stay visibly present: nodding and looking engaged is part of communicating, even in silence.

IN PRACTICE

A freelancer doubled his client wins by fixing three things on calls: a window in front of him for light, the camera at eye level on a stack of books, and opening every call with 'Here is what I understood you need - did I get it right?'

TRY THIS

Record a 45-second video pitch as if applying for a client or job. Check: eye-level camera, light on your face, point in the first five seconds. Redo until it feels natural.

Key takeaways

- Look at the lens to make eye contact.
- Light in front, camera at eye level.
- Lead with your point in the first five seconds online.

Your CEO-level talk

Everything in this book comes together in one deliverable: a three-minute talk that could open a door for you. Choose a real goal - introduce your project, pitch a service, or make a case for change in your community. Build it on Point, Proof, Ask. Rehearse it out loud at least ten times, not in your head.

Rehearsal is where amateurs and professionals split. Record each run, watch it, fix one thing, run again. By the tenth pass you will stop thinking about words and start thinking about the person in front of you - which is the whole point. Then deliver it for real to someone who matters.

IN PRACTICE

One learner rehearsed her hub pitch eleven times on her phone. On the twelfth, live, she barely looked nervous. The listener's first words were, 'You have clearly done this before.' She hadn't. She had just practised properly.

TRY THIS

Write and rehearse a 3-minute talk with a real audience in mind. Record ten takes, improving one thing each time. Deliver take eleven to a real person and ask for one piece of feedback.

Key takeaways

- Rehearse out loud and on camera, not in your head.
- Ten imperfect reps beat one perfect plan.
- A prepared three minutes can change your life.

KEEP GOING

Skills pay for life. Now go use them.

Finishing the reading is not the goal - finishing the project is. Pick the one exercise in this book that scared you most and do it this week. Then bring your work to your CHRISCO facilitator or post it online. That single habit - shipping real work - is what separates the youth who earn from the youth who only dream.

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